

4.02: Stasis Theory — How Arguments Begin

Objective: Understand the four kinds of arguments and practice identifying where a disagreement is actually happening.

Opening Discussion :

- People argue about complex issues like climate change, fast fashion, or waste all the time.
- What do you think people argue about most: facts, causes, seriousness (value), or solutions (policy)?
- Why do you think they get stuck on that specific stage?

What Is Stasis Theory?

Stasis theory is an ancient tool used to diagnose where a debate is stuck. The word "stasis" means a stand-off. It helps us stop talking past each other and figure out which fundamental question we need to answer first.

Stasis Theory Overview (Example: Clothing & Fast Fashion)

Stasis Type	The Goal (What are we arguing about?)	Example Question (Clothing)
1. Fact	Establish existence and scope using data	How many garments does the average American buy each year?
2. Cause	Identify origins, systems, and responsibility	Why has fast fashion become the dominant clothing model?
3. Quality (Value)	Judge seriousness, value, or ethics	To what extent is fast fashion harmful to workers and the environment?
4. Policy	Propose actions or solutions	What policies or practices could reduce clothing waste?

Part 3: Guided Practice — Stasis Sorting Activity (15 min)

For each statement below, determine which type of stasis argument (fact, cause, quality, policy) is being made. Then, explain why it fits that category (your explanation should mention **data**, **blame**, **values**, or **a call to action**).

Statement	Stasis Type	Why? (My reasoning)
A. Americans waste nearly 40% of food.		
B. Fast fashion exists because companies prioritize profit over durability.		
C. Consumer convenience is destroying the environment.		
D. Schools should ban single-use plastics.		
E. That car is a good value for the price.		
F. Social media algorithms cause polarization.		
G. The average household uses 300 gallons of water daily.		
H. The city should invest in a new light rail system.		

Part 4: Independent Practice — Applying the Concept to Your Topic

Look back at one of the topics from yesterday. See if you can develop a question for each stasis type about that topic. Make sure your questions align with the logic of that specific type. .

Stasis Type	My Question
1. Fact	
2. Cause	
3. Quality (Value)	
4. Policy	

Part 5: Exit Ticket (5 min)

Complete this sentence:

The kind of argument I'm most interested in making is [Fact / Cause / Quality / Policy] because....
